Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel

There is no better way to characterize G.W.F Hegel (1770-1831) than as a philosopher of truth. Like most classical and early modern thinkers, Hegel believed that the task of philosophy was to furnish as comprehensive and *true* an account of reality as possible. As in Aristotle or Spinoza, truth as a category implied extreme rigor, a uniquely wide breadth of scope—ranging from physics and ontology to politics and logic—and a capacity both to reflect the world as it actually is and to express it in the form of a system. Systematicity was for Hegel proof of thoroughness and of the muscularity of reason, but it also mirrored formally an important aspect of reality itself: the latter, he argued, was also a kind of system—an organized, deeply inter-connected, and (to some extent) *living* (or at least dynamic) whole. From a Hegelian standpoint, truth *exists* not just in the sense that it is possible, that it can be grasped, shared, and made actionable by humans (or perhaps other rational creatures), but that it is fundamentally this-worldly or immanent, rather than other-worldly or transcendent. Truth was not, as in Platonic Idealism, something that hovered over or preceded the world in the form of a static essence. Nor was it contained, ready-made, in the mind of God, an eternal logic or law that only had to be humbly recited by humans to be known. These ways of understanding truth, thought Hegel, reduced humans to passive instruments of a reality they had no hand in making themselves. Instead, truth was best understood as back-bendingly difficult *work*—a process that could be understood as simultaneously discovery (of something objectively there in the world) and invention (something we ourselves create and wilfully sustain). Despite Hegel's reputation in some circles as an austere theologian of eternity it is important to keep in mind the deeply existential dimension of Hegel's work, one that helps to explain why he was taken up so readily

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by twentieth-century thinkers such as Simone De Beauvoir, Jacques Lacan, Henri Lefebvre, and Jean-Paul Sartre.

Within idealist religious and philosophical traditions, the ultimate fruit of truth is usually peace and quiet. This is because truth for these traditions works to sidestep the complexity or uncertainty of the world via the promise of a sublime object (God) that once possessed puts an end to all contradiction, anxiety and doubt. For Hegel, however, truth is not the safe possession of a sublime object, but a stressful, contradictory and ongoing *activity* that brings the knower into intimate contact with the systematic determinacy of the world while simultaneously disclosing to it the meaning and purpose of knowing itself. To know the world without knowing its knower, without reflecting on the strangeness and *meaning* of knowing (but also the strangeness and meaning of being itself)—this for Hegel would be to abandon the very category of truth, one that lives or dies on its ability to encapsulate (and even *actualize*) the whole. Conceiving of truth in the form of a math equation, or as a set of first principles, or as the simple correspondence between a valid proposition and a state of affairs is, in Hegel's view, a far too partial and limited imagining of its scope. Such positions, besides taking far too much for granted, ultimately reduce knowledge to disinterested knowing—a kind of mute, disembodied gaze without obvious stakes or purpose beyond mere correctness.

The latter, of course, has a place in Hegel's system; it would make no sense to speak of a truth that wasn't correct (that didn't get things right, draw on the natural sciences, or attend to matters of fact). But for Hegel, truth goes far beyond simple correctness to include the deepest needs, hopes, and possibilities of human beings—considerations with vital consequences for how we exist in the world both individually and as a species. Truth tears the world and ourselves apart, implicating us in its own production, disaggregating common sense, and ranging across the

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whole of existence. Though Hegel's work may sometimes strike us as intolerably abstruse or abstract, his ultimate objective was in fact to intensely *concretize* human experience: to meaningfully situate us in history, to provide us with an immanent (and ennobling) ontology, to sharpen our awareness of the potentialities of existence, and in the end to deepen our sense of connection to (and participation in) the world unfolding all around us.

Hegel's Philosophy of History

Hegel used the word "negation" to describe how thought (but also many other types of human activity) breaks with forms of givenness to produce new ways of seeing (as well as shaping) both itself and the world. This capacity of the human being to break with immediacy occupies an important place in Hegel's system and is very close to functioning within it as something like an 'essence of the human'. If the idea that humanity has an *ergon* or nature seems to place Hegel close to Aristotle, we should be very clear about how truly strange and paradoxical this 'essence' is. We could say that the essence of the human, for Hegel, is to have no essence at all; its specific identifying characteristic among all other beings in existence (stones, stars, dolphins) is its remarkable capacity to freely (which always means *rationally*) determine itself—to negate what it has been, reflect on its possibilities, and to willfully become something else. The essence of the human, then, is its capacity to break with old ways of doing things and to freely and rationally determine itself, but also to evolve political institutions that allow people to live in communities that emphatically honour and safeguard this capacity. It is important to recognize that this isn't just a metaphysical conceit on the part of Hegel , though it does have important metaphysical implications; he is simply saying that we should render explicit an aspect of humanity's real historical practice that would otherwise remain implicit and

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unconscious. No species has experienced as diverse a set of modalities as humanity, ranging from shooting through space in jets to pledging to never again have sex. In addition to this, no species has the capacity to purposefully transform the world to the extent that humans can (and have), ranging from destroying the whole of the planet with nuclear weapons to re-shaping life on the level of DNA. The kind of change that matters for Hegel is not just change-for-its-own-sake, or mere difference, but change that qualitatively actualizes our essence—our capacities for self-consciousness, rationality and freedom.

The word Hegel uses as a synonym for the historically mediated and conflictual self-determination of humanity by itself is "spirit" (*Geist*). Though much confusion has been created by this choice of word, there is nothing transcendental or religious about what Hegel has in mind here. We are materially *in practice* self-differing, self-interpreting and self-determining beings, even if we often repress or forget this fact and confuse whatever shape our world has happened to take with nature or fate. Though Hegel does tend to elevate idea or spirit ("Being-for-Itself") above inert matter or unthinking bodiliness ("Being-in-itself"), he is very clear that we are living natural beings and like all such beings we are powerfully shaped by the form, instincts and limits of our animal bodies, as well as the physical world in which they move. The untranscendable condition of spirit is the existence of bodies in a determinate space and time. We are external, determined, flesh and blood creatures in a realist world of actually existent objects and relations. In this, Hegel is in basic agreement with the kind of materialist empiricism one finds in Machiavelli or Hobbes. However, we are also always *more* than whatever set of relations happen to presently determine and shape us at any given moment. The capacity for negation, then, can only ever be exercised within a particular set of local conditions and it is never wholly repressed or out-right negated by them. No givenness is permanent or absolute. The exercise of critical

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reason, the purposeful formation of new habits, a thorough education in the arts and sciences, and rationally configured social and political institutions were all seen by Hegel as establishing paths out of immediacy (or 'mere' animality) and towards the prospect of a fully actualized human life.

Actuality (*Wirklichkeit*), a concept Hegel derives from Aristotle, suggests the coming into existence of a way of being that is natural or necessary to something—its fulfillment or completion in line with an innate set of generic capacities. Human actualization, for Hegel and many of his contemporaries, meant self-realization—an unfinishable project of pushing the self (and the species as a whole) to the edge of its own capacities and limits. Though this may sound like Friedrich Nietzsche or Gilles Deleuze, Hegel didn't see the proliferation of new experiences or forms of life as an end in itself. He was not interested in novelty for its own sake. Instead, self-realization, however open-ended and ongoing, also involved a kind of paradoxical closure. An individual or a society can in this sense only go to the edge of its own limits by explicitly *limiting* itself, by excluding certain possibilities, privileging others, and focusing on particular kinds of ideals and goals at the expense of alternatives. A society in which people did whatever they wanted to—away from self-discipline, education and the good of the state—would be a society of humanoid animals for whom the unique human capacity for free self-determination had disappeared into the immediacy of whim. Self-actualization, then, involved the full development of our *essential* capacities, a commitment to the singular expression of one's own unique existence, and a life characterized by moral clarity, public purpose, and a deeply experienced sense for one's place in the totality of what exists.

For Hegel, this was inseparable from life-long engagement in a political community founded on rational laws and mutual recognition. Humans, unlike other animals, could be

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radically different from themselves and were uniquely subject to transformation on the basis of introjected rational norms and values that could come to refine and habituate them in ways inconceivable for other forms of life. No amount of training or education, claimed Hegel, will ever transform a bat into a metaphysician or citizen. Post-structuralist and post-humanist critics have interpreted these kinds of claims as chauvinistically humanist—precisely the kind of thinking, for example, that leads us to industrialize the mass production, slaughter, and consumption of animals. Hegel, though, felt he was pointing to an objective attribute of the species: humans were zoologically distinct and this distinctness had profound ontological implications—implications for *being itself*.

Any aspiration to truth involved reflecting critically not just on those aspects of our beliefs and behaviour that had been unconsciously layered into us by the structure of our animal bodies (instincts, drives, etc.), but also by the invisible common sense of our culture, social relations, and political institutions (what Hegel called our "second nature") ([1820] 1991, 35). "Dialectic" (*Dialektik*) was the name given by Hegel to the process by which thought, but also *things themselves*, were driven through conflict and opposition towards truth. This unending labour of the negative—the cobbling together of truer, more comprehensive understandings of the world out of the successes and failures of less convincing, less substantive versions—was on his account intrinsically social and historical. Though knowledge was often pushed forwards into greater complexity and self-awareness by world-historical individuals—visionary thinkers, inventors, artists, and political leaders—these figures shaped their positions on the terrain of the inherited logics and values of the culture and era into which they'd been born.

Despite the fact he is often associated with the concept, Hegel himself did not directly use Johann Herder's term *Zeitgeist* (or "spirit of the age"); it does, however, align well with what

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Hegel had in mind here. Truth could be driven into existence as much by an important scientific treatise as it could be a war, crisis, or revolution: what mattered was that a new order was instantiated that represented progress vis-à-vis earlier ways of seeing or being in the world. To say that thought was dialectical was to suggest that it could not occur in a vacuum, that it was always pre- or trans-individual, that it created novelty out of tensions and impasses, and that it was never wholly responsible for its own content. Thought was intrinsically social; no human was the self-transparent origin of themselves nor their view of the world, even if the goal of rational, free self-determination—both for individuals and the species as a whole—was the highest Hegelian ideal. This ideal, as in Johann Fichte, should probably be understood as regulative (in the Kantian sense)—a target for action, something to endlessly aspire to, rather than a state of affairs that had already been (or ever could be) fully achieved.

For Hegel, it wasn't simply individuals who in the end could have more comprehensive or truer accounts of the world—it was entire societies and peoples. These accounts in and out of existence in tense dialectical contestation with the material and social conditions that produced them; however, it was mostly in the domain of self-understandings and the impasses that they encountered that the shape and fate of a form of life or culture was decided. Though Hegel would have agreed with the 19th C historian Leopold von Ranke that every era enjoyed a special relationship to truth—a relationship to God / being / the whole that captured some aspect of reality and that deserved to be honoured in its own right—he would also have insisted on the fact that there was a critical difference between modernity and what came before it. The remarkable determinacy of the knowledge of the world produced by the natural sciences, the principle of individual subjectivity (or conscience) introduced into culture by Martin Luther's Reformation,

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and the self-grounding political ideals posited by the French Revolution had all changed the world in a way that was effectively irreversible.

Hegel, then, preserves the moment of truth of historicism without allowing it to devolve into unadulterated cultural relativism (every form of life, no matter how brutal, limited, or unfree is equally true, valuable, or just). According to Hegel, every people and culture that had ever existed had made visible some enduring or essential aspect of the nature of things. They had done so *rationally*—that is, with a measure of internal coherence and consistency—even if they cannot for Hegel be said to have developed their positions self-consciously nor done so using the kind of criteria for rationality employed by modern science and philosophy. For many critics, this argument is troublingly Eurocentric and even proto-imperialist. For others, Hegel's universalism fashions the groundwork for a transcultural repudiation of injustice—slavery, for example, or unchecked absolutism, both of which (from Hegel's perspective) are objectively incompatible with human nature.

Modernity, then, introduces into history a sharp break, one that simultaneously disorients us and opens up for us new possibilities of being. History was a process of learning, not in such a way that everything that came before Hegel was stupid, childish or false, but in the sense that every step in the process was provisionally true, though in a limited, contradictory way that forced thought to move beyond itself to a new and more complete conceptions of things. It is true, for example, that everything is connected, but left in this form such a view of the world is at the same time limited or false. Not everything, after all, is connected in the same way and some things are more closely connected than others. History, for Hegel, tracked the movement of humanity towards increasingly far-reaching and meta-reflective understandings of reality. Its arc was a messy, sometimes regressive, often zig-zaggy and violent story of human beings grappling

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towards the truth—a true picture of things that was at the same time isomorphic with a revelation of human essence as fundamentally (and disconcertingly) free. Truth and freedom were two sides of the same historico-dialectical adventure or experience (*Erfahrung*): the more thorough our knowledge of the world and ourselves the more we were capable of exercising our freedom and transforming both it and ourselves in line with the dictates of reason.

The paradox here is that though all humans were essentially (*in potentia*) free for Hegel not all forms of life were equal in their capacity to actualize this essence—to safeguard, incentivize, and enshrine it. He felt that the constitutional monarchies developing in German-speaking Europe in the wake of the Napoleonic occupation of the Rhineland (1806-1813) provided a template for a social set-up that finally honoured, rather than fundamentally repressed, our potential as a species. These states, thought Hegel, were unique. Their economies were increasingly liberalized and had begun to leave behind feudal conceptions of blood-based right. They placed an important emphasis on mandatory, secular education and aimed to create universities built on Humboldtian principles of well-roundedness, self-actualization and active, life-long citizenship. Their governments were slowly becoming staffed by professional, well-educated civil servants, rather than the aristocratic entourages that had characterized early modern absolutism. Industrious middle-class citizens were also now demanding more rational, consistent and transparent forms of government. They wanted a free press, rule of law, published legal codes, and parliaments grounded in censitary suffrage. For Hegel, these states, though still very much works in progress, blended rights and duties, liberty and constraint, in a manner consistent with the fundamental flourishing of human rationality and freedom. They were, in his view, *objective* improvements on what had come before.

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The 19th C Context of Hegel's Conception of Truth

Rather than being mystical or revealed—the purview of a closed spiritual patriciate—truth for Hegel could be grasped with effort by any human regardless of race, class, culture or gender, through the exercise of speculative reason. Whether or not one gained access to truth in its absolute sense had everything to with the time, place and conditions into which one was born. In this he was a true inheritor of the Cartesian rationalist tradition and at least epistemologically a committed egalitarian. Though the natural sciences were important for Hegel, truth could be communicated to others with the highest degree of lucidity primarily through the medium of philosophy, and to a lesser extent via the fuzzier practices of religion and art—ways of knowing that were seen to operate through images and stories and that primarily mobilized the feelings. Hegel, then, insists on the special truth-bearing prerogative of philosophy/science—the word *Wissenschaft* for Hegel covers both of these domains—and of conceptual reasoning without directly negating religion and art as complementary paths to truth. This choice allows him to mediate between a number of competing epistemological traditions and tendencies. It allows him, first, to conserve the value placed on aesthetic experience by Romanticism, but without subordinating rationality to self-expression or intuition. Hegel felt that the emphasis on the moral or alethic dimensions of art—seen clearly in the works of J.C.F Schiller, K.W.F Schlegel, F.W.J. Schelling, J.W Goethe, Wilhelm Humboldt and others—could function as a countermeasure to positivistic empiricism, a position that to Hegel's eyes appeared spiritless, incurious and limited. A world reduced to the hard gaze of the empiricist natural sciences, but separated from God, metaphysics, and absolute truth, stood to be industrious and precise, but risked being emptied of spiritual vitality and comprehensiveness. Such a world, thought Hegel, gained specificity at the

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expense of totality; it could know a great deal about small parts or specific zones of reality but nothing at all about the nature of the whole.

At the same time, Hegel was able to reject the association, made by thinkers like F.H Jacobi in the late 18th C, of Enlightenment rationality with French materialism or atheism. This allowed him to conserve the value of religion without lapsing into Romantic irrationalism, Lutheran orthodoxy or the need for a fideist leap of faith. By leaving a place for religion in his system, Hegel also deftly avoided the state censorship that would increase across Europe in the wake of the Congress of Vienna and the defeat of Napoleonic liberalism. Truth in its deepest sense, what Hegel called "absolute knowledge" (*Das absolute Wissen*), was only possible through philosophy--on this he was very clear--though the true philosopher for Hegel was nevertheless someone infused by refined, and deeply felt, religious and aesthetic sensibilities. Hegel's system was not necessarily incompatible with institutionalized religion--it had ritual and ethical functions that he seemed to think were vital to the flourishing of a well-ordered society. However, Hegel was at times in his life deeply suspicious of what he called "positive" religion—dogmatic forms of faith that denigrated reason and human autonomy and that confused the life of the spirit with unthinking obedience or conformity (2011, 71).

It is important to keep in mind that Hegel's philosophy of truth was formulated as the solution to a very specific historical conjuncture. Though his prose can feel abstract and removed from the concerns of everyday life, his work was an urgent intervention into a time of crisis and change. By pointing to the real similarities between Hegel's philosophy of truth and its classical and early modern antecedents—Aristotle, for example, or Spinoza—we should be careful not to neglect both its novelty and its unique theoretical *athleticism*. Hegel's project was not an anxious retreat to the solid ground of a pre-Kantian metaphysics—the kind we often today associate with

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G.W. Leibniz or Christian Wolff—but a set of extremely agile and difficult moves made within a crowded and in many ways inhospitable philosophical terrain. Truth, after all, was everywhere in crisis in Europe at the end of the 18th C. Since the 16th C skepticism had begun to nibble away at the edges of philosophical certitude. It wasn't just metaphysical entities like God or Spirt that were being called into question, but the existence of other minds and even the material world itself. Some feared nothingness was on the cusp of becoming everything. The emergence of capitalism and societies grounded in commodity exchange had displaced stable norms, hierarchies and long-standing forms of life and replaced them with a dynamic, mutable culture of business that to many 18th C eyes looked vulgar, anarchic, and bereft of ultimate purpose. The French Revolution had challenged the apparent naturalness of Christian monarchism, a model of sovereignty anchored in the divine rights of kings, and encouraged a new set of republican, democratic, and liberal political ideals grounded in the ostensibly natural rights and liberties of individuals. Sovereignty (at least in theory) stood to be derived from 'the people', but who precisely did this include (men, property-owners, peasants?), what limits could be placed on its desire, and how would a society characterized by universally incentivized egoism, new forms of ideological division, and increasing class tensions actually govern itself? At the same time, influenced by Justus Möser and Johann Herder, conservative historicists like Karl von Savigny and Ranke espoused an anti-Enlightenment cultural relativism, for which all truth and goodness was in the end *local*. There was no progressive arc to history, nor any overarching moral or ontological truth deducible to human reason out of the chaos of history; this allowed them to negate the claims to universality of liberal declarations of natural freedoms and rights). The kind of suspicion of absolute truth that would eventually find expression in Nietzsche (and later Emil Cioran or Jacques Derrida) was very much in the air during Hegel's own life.

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Thinkers like John Locke and Immanuel Kant had tried to anticipate these trends by tethering the non-philosophical practice of the applied natural sciences to stable philosophical ground. Their goal was to safeguard truth against skeptical and relativist critiques by providing empiricism with an epistemology. But they had done so at the expense of a knowledge of things-in-themselves and metaphysical accounts of the universe as a whole. They had gained the consistency and coherence of the world of appearances, but they couldn't explain where that world had come from, what it was in the deepest possible sense, nor attribute to it any kind of ultimate meaning or purpose. Kant, then, had won the objectivity of the natural sciences, but by housing it paradoxically within the confines of a transcendental subjectivity de-linked from things themselves; he conjectured that the latter existed—he remained in this sense a realist—but he insisted that what the world was 'in itself' would always remain a mystery to us. Schelling had tried to respond to this situation by maintaining a connection between philosophy and "the absolute". This was a word that pointed to the unconditioned, or that which was known in and through itself, and that often functioned as a synonym for God, nature, or the whole within the German Idealist tradition. But he did so by derogating reason and dissolving the determinacy of the world in a moment of intuition in which all things could be perceived as one.

Hegel's response to this was fascinating. If truth had been dissected to death by reason—faith, immediacy and inherited custom replaced with empiricist science and Cartesian/Kantian doubt—it was nevertheless reason alone that could put truth (and by implication the world) back together again. We could never escape the mediation of concepts; those promising to restore the world through feeling, religion, intuition, tradition, or a non-interventionist 'letting be' always did so within a language of categories with specific histories, limits and presuppositions. Significantly, for Hegel, this 'putting back together again' of the world was not restorationist or

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nostalgic, but the invention of something never seen before. There was no moving backwards through the epistemological quibbles of modernity to a substantial immediacy that would soothe and orient us once and for all. Hegel was very clear on this point—we can't just go back to being spiritually-centred and fulfilled Athenians or Spartans. We could, however, *through reason itself* achieve a provisionally whole account of the world—perhaps not with Cartesian certitude, and certainly not one that was finished or complete—but an account nevertheless that would offer us the widest and deepest of perspectives on the universe and our place in it. This wouldn't mean leaving uncertainty, opacity or questions behind; it meant striving to live, as best as any human can, a rational life.

Another way to put this would be to say that Hegel believed we could find a path to remaining modern and ancient *at the same time*. We could have all of the advantages of modernity—science, freedom, markets, constitutions, and individualism—without lapsing into nihilism, anomie, or chaos. We could at the same time have all of the enduring advantages of J.J Winkelmann's ancient *polis*—a sense of wholeness, purpose, meaningful relationships to nature, ourselves, and others—without requiring a political economy founded on slavery or a state that foreclosed free thought and activity by submerging reason in unquestionable myth. The sharp opposition between the ancient and the modern, between a world in which things were to some extent taken as given—the outcome of God, nature or fate or necessity—and one in which everything was mercilessly submitted to Kantian criticism could be overcome, but only through reason itself and a world and culture in which it was allowed to freely circulate. This synthesis of old and new could only take place within a particular societal organization, one that was simultaneously a project still in need of completion, and a historical process already taking place world-wide. The question of metaphysical truth, then, was not just a scholarly affair for Hegel,

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but something of urgent concern to the everyday life of a society: Hegel argues that the loss of a nation's capacity to think metaphysically—and by this he means comprehensively, in-depth, with a view to the most wide-ranging speculations—is as grave a turn culturally as its ignorance of its own laws or constitution. In the wake of Hegel's project, we would no longer be imprisoned in appearances as in Locke and Kant, having gained the consistency of science at the expense of metaphysical truth; nor would we gain access to the absolute (as in Schelling or Schlegel) at the cost of our rationality. We would not simply reflectively *know*, but *dwell* within truth: we would have become creatures of truth in societies explicitly built around it. Reason would be there present in a society's institutions—its universities, its constitution and laws, its mode of production—and on the level of the behaviour and even desire of the individual.

Hegel's project then is emphatically modern, and open to continued reform, but suspicious of revolutionary projects that seek to re-build society from the ground up in line with a master plan. He shared this anxiety with German conservatives like Adam Müller or Friedrich Gentz. He did not, like Mao Zedong, seek to eliminate tradition in the name of a hitherto unimaginable conception of justice, but to evolve something new that moves beyond the past *from within*. Hegel sees reason working slowly across the arc of history. Some of the forms evolved by human practice (slavery for example) pass out of existence in line with new standards of rationality; others persist and continue to function, their scale and meaning altered, in a new and more rational dispensation. For example, Hegel sees the family as an ancient institution that should not be allowed to dominate the logic of society as a whole—as it did throughout much of history—but that nevertheless continues to offer a means of socialization vital to the functioning of a modern state faced by new forms of market-based anomie and alienation. It is an old organ in a new body; it doesn't mean the same thing it did in ancient Greece or medieval Europe, but

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many of the same functions it had in these contexts continue to operate in the present and are essential to the reproduction of modern life. These seemingly archaic or residual organs often have a binding or necessary quality in Hegel's system and at times seem like speculative excuses to maintain the world as it already is. For example, he thought that only the married were truly free and that it was the ontological duty of women to reproduce. Marxists, feminists, queer theorists, and post-colonial critics have taken issue with many of these residual elements. In addition to seeing these remainders as ideological blind-spots, we can understand them as Hegel's attempts at historical *mediation*, a kind of *Realpolitik* that sought out paths to reform that avoided openly antagonizing the past (and those dominant classes whose interests continued to be powerfully aligned with it).

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Hegel's Absolute

If, then, for Hegel, the object of philosophy is the "actual cognition of what truly is," what exactly is the content of this 'is' ([1807] 1977, 46). What is Hegel's absolute? From one angle, it was simply nature understood as an interconnected, self-relating whole. We can make this claim on the condition that we recognize that within Hegel's work nature and being-in-itself did not entirely overlap as categories. Nature, for Hegel, was a closed system of relations and elements governed consistently by scientifically discoverable laws. These laws were discoverable both by the empirical efforts of the natural sciences and by speculative dialectics of the kind practiced by Hegel in his magisterial *Science of Logic* (1812-1816). To insist on the wholeness of nature was to declare it metaphysically one, rather than many—to declare it ontologically primary and self-subsistent rather than secondary and dependent. Though this can seem an obscure point today, to declare oneself a monist in 18th C Europe was to boldly associate

oneself with the work of Baruch Spinoza, a controversial figure whose fully immanent, naturalistic ontology had provoked accusations of godless materialism. If God was co-extensive with the laws of nature, what was left of the personal, providential father-figure of the Bible? The upshot of this position philosophically was that nature no longer relied for something outside it for its own creation or sustenance. The will of God, miracles, or vague spiritual forces ceased to function as legitimate explanations for phenomena. Hegel agreed with Spinoza that an understanding of the world as consistently rule-bound was the precondition to freeing humanity from superstition and fear.

In addition to this, Hegel's monism allowed him to bypass the many dualisms—between subject and object, mind and body, spirit and matter—that had begun to trouble European philosophy in the wake of René Descartes and that were still clearly present in the works of Kant and Fichte. Reality was not, as it was for Descartes, a contradictory binary in which the spontaneity of human thought lived mysteriously within an otherwise mechanist natural world characterized by blind externality and determinism. Descartes needed theism and the providential will of God to overcome this binary; Hegel, committed to true immanence, decided to abandon it. At the same time, Hegel's grasp of the whole and on the fundamental oneness of things did not come at the expense of their internal variety and complexity. What is can be said to be one, but this oneness does not have to cancel out its determinacy; it can be said to be whole, but this wholeness needn't erase particularity. The absolute or whole, then, is an internally differentiated system in which things have particular kinds of relationships to themselves, each other and the whole and in which change in one dimension of the totality impacts relations at other points in the system. To know what something is one has to know how it fits into the totality of nature/being. A concept, language, institution, or animal cannot be understood in a vacuum or

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apart from the relations that structure it both from within and from the outside. Nothing, in other words, can be understood apart from its relations to other things.

But Hegel did not stop at the identification of the absolute with the totality of nature. Had he done so, he would have remained within the deterministic naturalism of Spinoza and a model of reality that was fundamentally ahistorical and static. He is very clear: "[E]verything turns on grasping and expressing the True not only as *Substance* but equally as *Subject*" ([1807] 1977, 10). The absolute, then, is not simply an unchanging totality—a system of necessary, objectivistic relations and laws—but also a *result*, as well as the *process* that led to that result. It is, writes Hegel, the "process of its own becoming": "only by being worked out to its end [is it] actual" (10). For us moderns (or post-moderns), this is certainly a bizarre idea. Like Spinoza, we tend to think of nature as non-teleological; it is, we might concede, a process, but one without a purpose or end. What could it possibly mean to speak of a moment in the history of nature or humanity as having more reality (or more actuality) than another? Hegel, however, is adamant that the whole—being/nature/existence—is really only itself (and properly absolut*e*) once it becomes self-aware through *Wissenschaft* and capable historically, culturally and politically of free self-determination both on the level of the individual and the species as a whole. Being/nature/existence is in this sense *completed* by history just as history itself is by the development of human self-consciousness (as mentioned above, however, this becoming-complete of being is a necessarily unfinishable process). Human beings, after all, are a part of nature; why shouldn't we see the process by which we come to understand and then determine ourselves as nature emerging into self-consciousness *through* us.

In absolute knowledge the subject comes to know itself as object (as a systematic natural necessity) even as the object (the system of nature) comes to know and grasp itself as freely self-

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determining subjectivity. In other words, the object comes to know itself as a form of nature that breaks its own laws through negation and that ultimately gives itself its own content. The teleology at work here does not suggest a pre-formed consciousness nor need it even imply necessity, though this latter point is debatable. A common (mis)reading of Hegel tells the story of absolute knowledge as somehow planned in advance by a cosmic spirit outside of space and time. According to this account, God is an eternal, yet immaterial being (a *logos* whose deep essence was laid out by Hegel in his *Science of Logic*), that then chooses to externalize itself in nature and history as a means to its own self-actualization. If this were true, then Hegel would clearly not be a philosopher of immanence. If, however, Hegel's metaphysics are consistently immanent then the teleology at work in his system must instead be unconscious or inchoate; a 'desire', instinct or structural tendency that drives being into a transformative encounter with itself, rather than a plan laid out in advance.

Though much of the above account has focused on Hegel's philosophy of history, Hegel's system was in fact divided into three core domains: logic, nature, and spirit. Keeping in mind the caveats mentioned above, all three of these fields could be said to take as their object God (or the absolute) insofar as God is at once: a) an eternally necessary, but *not* materially existent, conscious or actualized logos (logic); b) an unendingly auto-productive and unconscious natural totality (nature) and c) the historical process by which humanity gropes towards its own self-actualization (spirit) (detailed above). Taken together these fields lay out the coordinates of everything that exists (or ever *could* exist). They reveal, in other words, the structure, direction, and *meaning* of being.

Hegel's logic today (alongside his philosophy of nature) remains at odds with the spirit of much contemporary philosophy and theory. In it, he tried to ascertain aprioristically core

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categories of reality by simply allowing the contradictions of pure, presuppositionless thought to resolve themselves dialectically into more and more satisfactory descriptions of being. These descriptions increase in determinacy, complexity, concreteness, and overall adequacy, as well as self-awareness and self-relatedness (just as history's own self-understanding arcs towards greater and greater levels of clarity). This process, one that begins at thought simply left to itself, away from any determinate content, culminates in absolute idea— the idea of an internally-differentiated organic whole driven to (and capable of) both rationally comprehending and freely determining itself. This is a whole, as we have seen, that is at once subject and object and that can only be said to actually or properly exist at the end of the process. Hegel's logic is not a set of formal rules for correct thinking; it is an attempt to evolve out of pure thought, step by step, the structure of reality itself. The dialectical concepts, relationships, and contradictions discovered by thought apply not only to itself, but to any possible reality (they are, echoing Aristotle, in things themselves).

Hegel's philosophy of nature, at once incumbent upon, yet epistemologically distinct from the natural sciences, consists of speculative reflections on the ontological meaning of nature and on its role in the historical unfolding of spirit. Like Aristotle, Hegel constructs a vertical ontology in which beings at the bottom of the natural order (chemicals, stones, plants) are almost entirely determined from the outside and those at the top (animals, humans, philosophers) are characterized by high levels of complexity and capacities for self-awareness and self-determination. Nature, then, is never simply the opposite of spirit because the latter is inconceivable apart from the former; spirit, however is nevertheless categorically *special*, in that it is a form of nature, unlike chemistry, that systematically breaks its own laws (or that determines its own content). That said, even in it most literally 'unthinking' forms—say in the

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shape of light or space—nature is always to some extent 'spiritual'. This does not mean that Hegel is saying that nature is mind or the product of mind (this would make him a subjective rather than an objective idealist), but that there are thought-like aspects within nature, particularly its capacity to substantially differ from or non-coincide with itself. The world is not a static frozen One—it is not an inert lump. It is dynamic and self-differing, auto-productive and self-organizing. Matter itself, then, has a certain vitality or energy, a certain negativity, or driving self-difference, that animates it and moves it beyond itself (even if it remains categorically distinct from spirit). For Slavoj Žižek this 'spirit' of nature is nothing more than negativity and allows us to envision a Hegelian nature fully compatible with secular modern cosmology (the big bang), Darwinian evolution, and recent innovations within theoretical physics. For more traditional interpretations, this spirit is not intrinsically self-conscious, but something like a *tendency* to self-consciousness. This isn't really a *desire* for self-knowledge, but an ontological openness to it. In its most teleological and organistic forms it has been imagined like an embryo (or oak seed); understood in a less teleological way it would be nothing more than an ontological propensity—a chance or likelihood built into the structure of being itself.

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Hegel's Reception

In terms of legacy, only Charles Darwin or Karl Marx among 19th C thinkers can be said to have had a greater impact than Hegel on subsequent European philosophy and thought. This legacy, however, is fundamentally ambivalent, and in two senses. First, concerning the *quality* of this influence, Hegel, like Marx, has sharply divided readers, often forcing them to choose between a certain critical fidelity to his project and outright, root-and-branch denunciation. Though Hegel has directly inspired some of the most important schools of 20th C philosophy—

Marxism, existentialism, and phenomenology, for example—he has just as often been used as the central foil for theoretical positions opposed to his own. Theorists have felt the need to invoke Hegel, often in caricature, to highlight the novelty or significance of their position; this was especially the case for analytic philosophers and post-structuralists in the 20th C for whom Hegel was configured as a primary enemy or threat. Second, Hegel's legacy is ambivalent because interpretations of his project, even by serious life-long readers of his work, have been characterized by an unusual level of dissensus. There is perhaps no figure in the history of philosophy who has engendered a more diverse and sharply conflicting set of interpretations than Hegel. This is an effect a) of Hegel's infamously difficult style; b) the systematic structure of his project, which requires that one constantly situate oneself both regionally and within the system as a whole to understand what's going on ; c) the nature of the dialectic itself, which de-stabilizes truth-claims by placing them into constant tension with rival claims; d) the constrained speech-context of 19th C absolutism, which forced Hegel to mask his positions with a view to avoiding censors; and e) the wide-ranging scope of Hegel's project, which forces readers to move between historical, logical, and ontological registers that are today usually kept apart. This means that virtually no aspect of the account I have given above would be universally conceded by Hegel specialists. Though Hegel is often framed as monolithic, and contrasted with someone like Georges Bataille, whose work is seen as more fragmentary and open-ended, in fact Hegel's oeuvre has generated a far more diverse set of interpretations. Bataille's writing is certainly ambivalent, and often internally contradictory, but nobody today thinks he was a Christian, an enlightenment rationalist or a committed liberal democrat.

While he was alive many readers—thinkers like Carl Friedrich Göschel and Philip Marheineke—saw Hegel as a liberal conservative who championed establishment values of order

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and tradition while at the same time leaving open the possibility of limited progressive reform. This meant that he would be open to a formal constitution, for example, or a slight liberalization of the economy. For them, Hegel's rationalist metaphysics, centred on the teleological unfolding of God's identity in history, was compatible both with Lutheran orthodoxy and enlightened Prussian absolutism. In the 1840s, a new generation of Hegelians, thinkers like Ludwig Feuerbach, Bruno Bauer, and Karl Marx broke with these readings and instead focused on the ways Hegel's immanent metaphysics and commitments to free self-determination undercut established religious and political authority and built the groundwork for an atheist materialism that was neither deterministic nor reductive. Hegel's strict rationalism; his (limited) commitment to liberal rights and freedoms (rule of law, rights to choose one's own career, freedom of the press, etc.); the dependence of his understanding of freedom on notions of autonomy and self-determination; but also his insistence on including (restricted) self-government and political participation as key criteria of a state's legitimacy could be expanded to fit the political programs of secular radical democrats like Arnold Ruge as well as socialists like Moses Hess or Ferdinand Lassalle. Whether Hegel's work was conservative, liberal, or a closeted form of radicalism became an object of intense speculation and debate.

Hegel's most influential 'follower' was, of course, Marx. The latter, however, found much to critique in the work of Hegel, so much, in fact, that scholars are still undecided about the extent of Marx's debts to his predecessor. Broadly speaking, Marx thought that Hegel's philosophy of history was incorrigibly idealist, granting too much weight to the role played by ideas and consciousness in history and too little to material forces and social relations. In the light of Marx's historical materialism—a philosophy grounded in economics, sociology, and history—both Hegel's science of logic and his philosophy of nature appeared so badly

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contaminated by metaphysics that they risked becoming obsolete. In Marx's view, Hegel lacked a clear sense for the ways conflicts between ideas mirrored divisions between classes; had erred in making property a pre-condition of individual freedom; and had ultimately placed too much faith in the state and its ostensibly universal (or dis-interested) bureaucratic elite. Many aspects of Hegel's system, thought Marx, seemed crafted to accommodate the status quo rather than to disrupt it with a view to the creation of something better. Why, for example, should aristocratic landowners be granted control of the upper house of a bi-cameral assembly? Why should Hegel's ideal political system be a constitutional monarchy based on a hereditary principle of succession? Marx found the speculative logic justifying these arrangements—and many others in Hegel's system—unpersuasive.

Despite these critiques, Marx's work remains unthinkable apart from its Hegelian inheritance. The emphasis placed by Marx on the fundamental historicity of humans; on the connection between truth and totality; on the ways that thought and behaviour are shaped immanently by unseen ('transcendental') structures; and on the metaphysical blind-spots and contradictions of free-market individualism are all derived to a large extent from Hegel. Though dialectics is not a formal method or instrument, the habit of treating concepts as historical traces that are fluid, interconnected, and shot through by tensions was one Marx borrowed directly from Hegel as well. Even if Marx spends very little time explicitly theorizing freedom, it is as central to his own project as it was to Hegel's; it is at the very heart of Marx's critique of capitalism and the basic *raison d'être* for his avowal of a communist alternative. For Hegel, the task was to free spirit from forms of objectivity—slavery, absolutism, and positive religion—that mystified or distorted its ontological openness. Marx continued this project but extended it beyond critiques of natural hierarchy and dogma. He openly rejected religion, any and all state structures

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including those grounded in naturalized individual rights and freedoms, as well as capitalism as a mode of production that Marx felt systematically de-potentiated human beings and separated them from the possibility of living lives that were healthier, more meaningful, and genuinely free. Marx's masterpiece, *Das Kapital*, is best understood as a synthesis of Hegelian dialectics and British political economy combined with an empiricist historical inquiry into the granular details of life under capitalism. The emmeshing of Hegel's fate with the legacy of Marxism means that Hegel was indirectly folded into the origins (through Marx) of whole disciplines—classical economics, sociology, and political science—though this has also meant that the same suspicions directed by liberals towards Marx have been aimed at Hegel as well. This is a kind of guilt by association that can be seen in attempts to paint Hegel, despite all of the evidence to the contrary, as an apologist for authoritarianism.

Hegel's status within the Marxist tradition has constantly fluctuated. For Second International Marxists like Karl Kautsky, who had been influenced by Engels's late systematization of Marx, Hegel tended to be seen as incompatible with the aspiration of historical materialism to an empiricist (or even positivist) social science. Reformist social democrat Eduard Bernstein came to reject Marx himself on the basis of his supposed contamination by the apriorism and metaphysical excesses of Hegel. This was a view often repeated by neo-classical critiques of Marx's economics. Strangely, however, this positivist or scientized version of Marx tended to be deeply teleological and necessitarian—meaning it saw the coming of socialism as inevitable in a way that echoed Hegel's own view of history as driven inexorably towards progress. For many, this economic or technological determinist view of history left little room for the agency (or subjectivity) of revolutionary workers, de-emphasized the role of contingency in history, and was increasingly at odds with facts on the ground which

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showed that capitalism in Western Europe was transforming in ways that made it less likely to be overthrown by a Marxist revolt. One paradoxical consequence of this situation was that it made the Marxists who embraced such a view look *less*, rather than more empiricist.

At the same time, the overly simplified dialectical formulas that structured Engels's dialectical materialism—formulas derived ostensibly from Hegel himself and thought to apply not only to history, but to nature itself—would find their way into institutionalized Soviet philosophy as well as into the official dogma of communist parties all over the world. This was certainly ironic—Soviet philosophers framed their version of Marxism as scientistic, freed from idealist metaphysics and Marx as having decisively broken with Hegel in the name of materialism. Meanwhile, a tradition of Marxists that included György Lukács and Antonio Gramsci, rejected positivist interpretations of Marx and instead foregrounded the latter's proximity to Hegel—specifically his historicism, his humanism, and the political ideal of a consciously disalienated and fully self-determined society. They felt that Marxism was less a science than it was a historically relative revolutionary truth; they rejected deterministic interpretations of Marx, placing a greater emphasis on the role played by contingency in history; and they saw the consciousness and engagement of the whole of the working class as instrumental to the realization of any genuine communism. For them, it couldn't be imposed on the majority by the few or implemented behind the backs of workers through the objective workings of history.

This humanist, Hegelian Marxist alternative to institutionalized communist philosophy fell into crisis in the 1960s. The appearance of structuralism on the intellectual scene had radically changed the terrain on which Hegel and Marx were being read. It is in this context that Louis Althusser tried to synthesize Marx with the structuralist tradition. Althusser rejected the

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association of Marx with Hegel and drew a sharp line between the former's early works (which were still Hegelian and ostensibly polluted by ideological thinking) and a later series of texts that were properly scientific and had left Hegel behind. Marxism could break with Hegel, thought Althusser, without reverting to the naïve empiricism of Second International Marxism. Althusser re-framed Marx's project as an epistemologically sophisticated (non-positivist) science and rejected historicism as a politically dangerous (and theoretically confused) form of relativism. Armed with an idea of structural determination, Althusser problematized Hegel's focus on the subject—both on the individual and collective level—opting for a materialist deconstruction of the institutional processes that engender subjectivity in the first place. No subject was the origin of itself, nor ever could be; all processes of subjectivization were intrinsically ideological and emmeshed in complex webs of power relations; and history as a whole had no necessary purpose or destination, but was instead a "process without a subject". If a dominant form of Marxist theory in the early 21st C emerged out of the anti-Hegelian, Deleuze- and Foucault-inspired philosophy of Antonio Negri, a new generation of thinkers influenced by Slavoj Žižek has produced an innovative school of Marxist thought deeply indebted to Hegel (as well as Lacan). Fredric Jameson's dialectical criticism, derived in large part from the work of the Frankfurt School, has been synthesizing Marxist Hegelianism with structuralist and post-structuralist elements since the 1970s.

The main branches of 20th C philosophy all had ambivalent relationships to Hegel. Husserlian phenomenology sought to escape what it saw as the speculative excesses of German Idealism, as well as its abandonment of individual experience, and to transform philosophy into a (non-positivist) science of attention to the ways things actually appear to consciousness. If the early position of Edmund Husserl is idealist in that it fails to attend to the structural conditions of

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phenomenology, the spirit of his late work, interested in the way perception is always emmeshed in cultural and social forms, shows clear debts to Hegel's historicist epistemology. Martin Heidegger found in Hegelian negativity and historicity anticipations of his own project, but accused Hegel of remaining trapped within Cartesian subjectivity, failing to understand the connection between being and nothing, and subordinating ontology to a metaphysics of presence that was in the end a disguised form of theology. Jean-Paul Sartre's existentialism drew directly on Hegel's identification of human essence with negation and his conception of the subject as radically free to determine itself is certainly close to Hegel's own. His work, however, especially in *Being and Nothingness*, approached social conventions with a high degree of suspicion, tended to focus on the predicament of an existentially isolated individual, de-linked freedom from rationality, framed being as intrinsically meaningless or absurd (something Hegel would never concede), and contended that absolute knowledge was effectively impossible.

Analytic philosophy has for the most part been extremely hostile to Hegel. Bertrand Russell developed his philosophy in strong opposition to an idealist strain of British Hegelianism that had become influential towards the end of the 19th C. He rejected Hegel's holism—the world was not a whole, Russell argued, but an aggregation of atomic (or separate) facts—and he found Hegel's dialectical logic deeply irrational. He felt that the latter had forced Hegel to effectively abandon the law of non-contradiction. One thing may stand in a particular factual relationship to another thing, but the idea that everything is intrinsically related to everything else was in Russell's view meaningless. Breaking with dialectics, Russell chose instead to employ a conceptual notation derived from Gottlob Frege aimed at introducing the analytical preciseness of mathematics into language and philosophy. In Ludwig Wittgenstein's *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus*, truth was de-linked from ontology and ethics and framed instead as the

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coincidence of a logically valid proposition with an empirically verifiable states of affairs. Nothing precise could be said about metaphysical concepts like being or substance or about values like freedom or reason The task of philosophy would henceforth be to support the truth-claims of the natural sciences and to police language (as well as philosophy) for signs of metaphysical nonsense, with Hegel the ultimate culprit. A later generation of analytical philosophers, including Wilfrid Sellars and John McDowell, attempted to complicate this picture and laid down the conditions for a rapprochement between the analytical tradition and Hegel that would see its ultimate expression in Robert Brandom's magisterial *A Spirit of Trust*.

Structuralists in the 1950s mostly rejected Hegel as an idealist humanist whose work was unscientific and plagued by metaphysics, but a clear homology exists between the way structuralists conceive of meaning (and subjectivity) as effects of systems of signs and Hegel's own attention to the epistemologically mediated nature of reality. Post-structuralists like Michel Foucault, Jacques Derrida, Jean-Francois Lyotard and Gilles Deleuze had a highly antagonistic relationship to the Hegelian tradition. Most of these thinkers rejected Hegel's understanding of history as bad idealist teleology; his image of the subject as excessively Cartesian and unsustainably self-transparent; his rationalism as blinded by Enlightenment optimism; and the dialectic as a metaphysical conceit grounded in a logic of contradiction with little connection to the complexity, multiplicity and singularity of things. The intensity of the post-structuralist critique of Hegel often masked secret borrowings and continuities. Deleuze, like Hegel, was a metaphysician of immanence who rejected Cartesian dualism and saw thinking not as a theatre of representation, but as directly ontological. Though Foucault's discursive regimes were discontinuous and non-teleological, his understanding of the role played in knowledge by structure echoed Hegel's own image of truth as epistemologically mediated by systems of

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historical categories. Derrida was certainly opposed to many of the metaphysical hierarchies that governed Hegel's work, but a clear connection exists between the way meaning is generated out of differences in Hegel and Derrida's own (less teleological) concept of *différance*.

Post-colonial theorists have found a great deal to critique in Hegel, most importantly the way his philosophy of history ends up framing pre-modern or non-Western cultures as less knowledgeable or free than their modern European counterparts. For many post-colonial critics, Hegel is the purest expression of European exceptionalism and triumphalism, though Third-World communism, informed by Hegel through Marx, became one of the greatest sites of 20th C anti-imperialist resistance. Eco-critics have lauded Hegel's naturalism, his holistic sense for the interconnectedness of things, and the Gaia-like resonances of subject-object identity as elements well-suited to post-humanist views of nature. Others, however, have pointed to Hegel's vertical ontology—one that elevates self-subsistent subjectivity over heteronomous inter-dependence and unconsciousness—and the habit he had of framing freedom as conditional on the adversarial subordination of nature by humans as signs of an entrenched speciesism. The latter, they argue is a key part in the instrumentalization and exploitation of nature that has characterized the history of capitalist modernity. These concerns have been echoed in the work of New Materialists like Rosi Braidotti and Jane Bennett who find in Hegel's idealism not just an alibi for the derogation of animals, but inanimate objects as well. Rather than separate reality into subjects capable of agency and a physical world defined by its inability to break its own laws, they argue for a conception of matter as itself animate, self-differing, and lively. Similarly, Object Oriented Ontology longs to reject Hegel's focus on human rationality and consciousness, as well as his historicized Kantian epistemology, with a view to penetrating directly into the subterranean strangeness of things themselves. Hegel would have viewed these new materialisms with

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suspicion, responding that his own system had anticipated much of what is today organized under the category of the "post-human" and detecting in their one-sided criticism of the Enlightenment the oldest form of conservative irrationalism. Within and beyond the terms of the discussions outlined above, thinkers like Susan Buck-Morss, Judith Butler, Robert Pippin, Rebecca Comay, Timothy Brennan, Catherine Malabou, Frank Ruda, Karen Ng, Terry Pinkard, Adrian Johnston, Stephen Houlgate, and Andrew Cole continue to produce innovative re-interpretations of Hegel that ensure he'll be as central to 21st C debates as he was to those of the 20th.

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